

TAKE a CRACK

How would you create a Windows XP bootable CD that wouldn't require you to do any additional installation of drivers?

Send in your solution with the subject "Take a Crack", and your postal address, to takeacrack@thinkdigit.com

THIS MONTH'S CHALLENGE

Create an XP CD that requires no driver installation!



LAST MONTH'S CHALLENGE

Win!



Take a Crack and win

Corporate Actions

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LAST MONTH'S WINNER

Chaitanya Babu
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Rules and Regulations

Readers are requested to send in their answers by the 15th of the month of publication.

Employees of Jasubhai Digital Media and their relatives are not permitted to participate in this contest.

Readers are encouraged to send their replies by e-mail. Jasubhai Digital Media will not entertain any unsolicited communication.

Jasubhai Digital Media is not responsible for any damage to your system that may be caused while you are trying to solve the problem.

Make a USB drive a key to boot into XP

Last month's solution

In what follows, we describe the procedure for solving last month's problem, but you might still experience problems. If you do, you'll need more information about your motherboard, as we've mentioned towards the end of this solution.

The USB booting feature is usually found in most new motherboards. For older boards, a BIOS update is required.

For our task, a USB drive of a capacity of at least 256 MB is required. If we need to include extra utilities, hotfixes, and service packs, then we need at least a 512 MB drive.

Use the "USB Disk Storage Format Tool" from HP for formatting the USB drive. You can download this 2 MB utility from www.pctipp.ch/downloads/dl/32594.asp (<http://snipurl.com/tacdec>). Choose the USB Drive to be formatted, and select "FAT" under "File System". Enter a name of less than 11

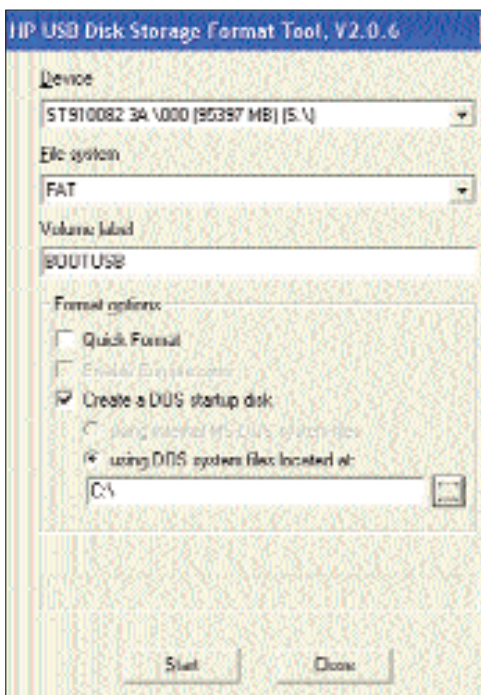


characters for Volume Label, and click Start to begin formatting. For a 1.1 USB port, this takes no more than a minute.

After having selected "Show hidden files and folders" and deactivating "Hide protected operating system files", navigate to the root directory on which Windows is located, usually C:\. Copy the boot.ini, ntdllr, and NTDETECT.COM files from that directory to the USB Flash drive. Rename the "boot.ini" in C:\ to "boot.bak". Windows will not now be able to boot from the hard drive, and the USB drive will be the key to unlocking the computer.

Now to check whether your USB drive works or not! Restart your PC and select the USB drive as the First Boot Device in the BIOS. For this test, deactivate the "Quick Boot" and "Show Full Screen Logo" options in order to be able to monitor any BIOS-reported activities. Also, the "USB Legacy Support" and "USB 2.0 Controller" options need to be activated if available. Save your changes and exit the BIOS, and restart.

If you encounter a problem booting, look for an option in the BIOS that extends the response time of the USB drive, for example, the "USB Mass Storage Reset Delay" option found in the AMI-BIOS. Choose the highest value and gradually decrease the value until the problem pops up again. This should work, but if the problem persists, check your motherboard manual or visit the Web site of your motherboard's manufacturer for a BIOS update. ■



The HP USB Disk Storage Format Tool